

A COZY HALLOWEEN MURDER MYSTERY PARTY GAME

The Candlewick *Costume Ball* MURDER

A Cozy Halloween Murder Mystery Party Game

6–14 PLAYERS · AGES 12+ · PRINTABLE PDF

HOST GUIDE · SPOILER-FREE

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

READ THIS FIRST · NO SPOILERS INSIDE

Host *Guide*



Everything you need to run The Candlewick Costume Ball Murder, even if you have never hosted a mystery. This guide never reveals the answer, so you can play along.

How the game works

1. **Every guest gets a character booklet** with a costume idea made from things in their closet.
2. **You play Detective Ira Gilchrist.** You are not a suspect. You read the scripts, keep time, and guess along with everyone.
3. **Three rounds.** Each round you read a short script and put out four evidence cards. Guests share what their booklet tells them, ask two named characters a question and try a small task.
4. **The Costume Parade** comes between Rounds 2 and 3: a fun break, with a Best Costume award.
5. **Accusation.** Everyone fills in a ballot: who, how, why and a key clue.
6. **The reveal.** A player opens the sealed solution (file 99) and reads Script 5 aloud. You score the ballots and hand out the awards.

Your job as the Detective

- Cast the game with the casting chart: the host plays the Detective, and every other character can go to anyone.
- Keep time, read Scripts 1–4 and put out each round's evidence.
- Make sure quiet guests get asked questions.

DON'T OPEN 99 YET

99-SOLUTION-Host-Only holds the answer. Don't open or print-preview it. Print it last and face down, or keep it on a phone, until every ballot is in. Then hand it to a player to read.

HOST TIP

Ask a helper (a family member or an early guest) to cut the evidence cards from file 30 and sort them into three envelopes without reading the fronts. Then nobody, including you, has seen the clues early.

SHORT ON TIME? START HERE

Party This *Weekend?*



Bought the game a day or two before the party? You can be ready in one hour of prep. Read this guide and file 99 on a screen, and print only what players hold in their hands.

Print only this (6 players)

File	What	Pages
10–15	The six core booklets, single-sided (4 pages each)	24
30	Evidence Cards, pages 1–2 only (skip the card backs)	2
32	Accusation Ballots: 1 sheet per 4 players, so 2 sheets	2
Total for 6 players		28

Skip for now: invitations (text the message on page 9 of file 02 instead), Cast List, name tags (use sticky labels), Detective Notes (plain paper works), awards and decor. More players? Add 4 pages per booklet; file 00 lists every guest count.

Your 1-hour prep plan

0–15 MIN · PRINT

- [ ] Print the 28 pages above.
- [ ] Read pages 2, 5 and 8 of this guide.

15–30 MIN · CUT

- [ ] A helper cuts the 12 cards into 3 envelopes: Round 1 (E1–E4), Round 2 (E5–E8), Round 3 (E9–E12).

30–45 MIN · CAST

- [ ] Give each guest a character (casting chart, page 5).
- [ ] Text each guest their costume line from their booklet's page 1.

45–60 MIN · SET THE ROOM

- [ ] LED candles, a few pumpkins, an evidence table, pens and a bowl for ballots.
- [ ] Open file 99 on a phone for later. Don't read it.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE · EXPRESS, 90 MINUTES

Arrival and quick Costume Parade 10 · Script 1 10 · Round 1 15 · Round 2 15 · Round 3 15 · Ballots 8 · Script 5 10 · Awards 7. The scripts are on pages 10–12 of this guide; read them straight from your phone.

Preparation Checklist

One to two weeks before

- [ ] Pick the date and the version: Evening Party (150 min) or Express (90 min).
- [ ] Confirm your guest count (6–14; up to 20 with pairs).
- [ ] Choose the booklets with the casting chart (page 5).
- [ ] Send invitations: file 02, the E-Invites folder, or the Invitation Maker.
- [ ] Share the Cast List (file 03) so guests can plan costumes.

A few days before

- [ ] Print the files on the print list in file 00.
- [ ] Ask a helper to cut the evidence cards into three envelopes.
- [ ] Print booklets single-sided; cut page 3 on its dashed line if you like.
- [ ] Cut name tags, ballots and any decorations.
- [ ] Seal file 99 in an envelope marked “Open last.”

On the day

- [ ] Hang the CANDLEWICK COSTUME BALL banner (file 35).
- [ ] Put up the Legend of the Lantern Ghost poster.
- [ ] Set an evidence table with its “Do Not Touch” sign (file 34).
- [ ] Lay out name tags, booklets, pens and Detective Notes.
- [ ] Make the hot cider or cocoa (page 15).
- [ ] Keep this guide and the three envelopes beside you.

Your party plan

DATE

START TIME

VERSION (EVENING / EXPRESS)

NUMBER OF PLAYERS

CARD-CUTTING HELPER

WHO READS SCRIPT 5

Casting Chart

6–14 PLAYERS · UP TO 20 WITH PAIRS

Count everyone who will hold a booklet. The host plays the Detective and does not need one. The six core booklets (10–15) are in every game; optional booklets join in number order, 16 first.

Players	Booklets to use	Booklet pages
6	10–15 (the six core booklets)	24
7	10–16 (adds 16 Auden Pryor)	28
8	10–17 (adds 17 Bexley Applegate)	32
9	10–18 (adds 18 Corin Thimble)	36
10	10–19 (adds 19 Larkin Hearthstone)	40
11	10–20 (adds 20 Teagan Bramwell)	44
12	10–21 (adds 21 Ainsley Duskwood)	48
13	10–22 (adds 22 Merritt Oxley)	52
14	10–23 (adds 23 Wynn Pennywhistle)	56

WHO PLAYS WHOM

The host plays Detective Ira Gilchrist; hand the other characters out however you like. Every character works for anyone: names are gender-neutral and booklets use names and "they," never he or she. Give the core booklets (10–15) to guests who are sure to come.

15–20 guests: share optional booklets in pairs

Guests	Booklets	Played by a pair
15	All 14 (10–23)	23
16	All 14 (10–23)	22 and 23
17	All 14 (10–23)	21, 22 and 23
18	All 14 (10–23)	20 to 23
19	All 14 (10–23)	19 to 23
20	All 14 (10–23)	18 to 23

A pair reads one booklet together and plays one character as a team (two cousins, two old friends). Print one blank name tag per extra guest.

Cuttable Characters

REMOVE 16–23 SAFELY

Fewer guests? Simply leave out the optional booklets, highest number first. The solution only depends on the six core booklets (10–15) and the twelve evidence cards, which you always use.

Booklet	Leave it out below	What it adds (nice, never needed)
16 Auden Pryor	7 players	Tells the Lantern Ghost legend; adds the brass-mold history.
17 Bexley Applegate	8 players	Explains the gallery cider kettle.
18 Corin Thimble	9 players	A second view of the parade line-up from the balcony.
19 Larkin Hearthstone	10 players	Notes how close the Back Stairs are to the Coat Room.
20 Teagan Bramwell	11 players	Adds the Back Stairs keys and the propped door.
21 Ainsley Duskwood	12 players	A black-cloak red herring and a fortune-teller act.
22 Merritt Oxley	13 players	Heard footsteps at 8:35; opens the deed of gift.
23 Wynn Pennywhistle	14 players	A photographer's eye on masks and face paint.

WHAT ALWAYS STAYS

Booklets 10–15, all 12 evidence cards (E1–E12), the ballots and the solution. Optional characters only ever ask questions of core characters or of optional characters with a lower number, so nobody is ever told to question someone who isn't playing.

A GUEST CANCELS ON THE DAY?

If an optional character drops out, nothing breaks: put their booklet away. If a core character (10–15) drops out, give that booklet to the guest with the highest optional number, and put the optional booklet away instead.

FEWER THAN 6 GUESTS?

This game needs at least six players. For 4–6 players, try our free mini mystery, The Case of the Cold Cocoa.

Timetable · Evening Party

150 MINUTES

The full version for an evening party. Write real clock times in the margin so you know when each part starts.

Part	Min	Running
Arrival: name tags, costumes, cider	15	15
Script 1: welcome, the Legend, read page 2	15	30
🎃 Round 1 · The Grand Entrance (E1–E4)	25	55
🎃🎃 Round 2 · The Lantern Ghost (E5–E8)	25	80
Costume Parade interlude (start of Script 4)	15	95
🎃🎃🎃 Round 3 · Unmasked (E9–E12)	25	120
Accusation ballots	10	130
Script 5: the reveal (file 99)	10	140
Scoring and awards	10	150
Total	150	**150 min**

STARTING LATE?

15 minutes late: cut Arrival to 5 and the Costume Parade to 10. **30 minutes late:** also cut each round from 25 to 20. **45 minutes or more:** switch to the Express timetable (page 8). Never skip a round: every round holds evidence.

HOST TIP

Give a five-minute warning before each round ends. If a corner goes quiet, ask: “Who has asked you a question yet?”

Timetable · Express

90 MINUTES

The same story, shorter: each round drops its task, and the Costume Parade happens as guests arrive. Good for a school-night party or after a family dinner.

Part	Min	Running
Arrival and a quick Costume Parade	10	10
Script 1 and reading page 2	10	20
🎃 Round 1 (skip the task)	15	35
🎃🎃 Round 2 (skip the task)	15	50
🎃🎃🎃 Round 3 (skip the task)	15	65
Accusation ballots	8	73
Script 5: the reveal	10	83
Scoring and awards	7	90
Total	90	**90 min**

STARTING LATE?

10 minutes late: cut Arrival to 5 and Script 1 to 5. **20 minutes late:** also cut each round to 12 and ballots to 5. **30 minutes or more:** use the 60-minute plan below.

ONLY 60 MINUTES?

Welcome and Script 1: 8 · Round 1: 10 · Round 2: 12 · Round 3: 12 · Ballots: 5 · Script 5: 8 · Scoring: 5 = 60 minutes. Players read page 2 before they arrive, and awards can be handed out the next day.

Setting Up

The evidence envelopes

Ask a helper who is not the host (a family member, or an early guest) to cut the evidence cards from file 30 without reading them. If you print the optional card backs on the reverse, they can cut face down. They sort the cards into three envelopes by the pumpkins on each card:

- 🎃 **Round 1:** E1, E2, E3, E4.
- 🎃🎃 **Round 2:** E5, E6, E7, E8.
- 🎃🎃🎃 **Round 3:** E9, E10, E11, E12.

The room

- An evidence table where everyone can read the cards without taking them away.
- A spot for the Costume Parade: a hallway, a rug or a cleared corner.
- The Legend of the Lantern Ghost poster near the door or the window.
- A ballot bowl (any bowl, hat or plastic cauldron) and pens.
- A quiet corner where people can read their booklets privately.

> **LED CANDLES ONLY**
> The story is full of candles, but please use battery LED candles and tea lights around costumes, capes and paper decorations. They look just as good.

The booklets

Hand each guest their booklet at the door, or send the PDF ahead. Page 1 can be read before the party (it has the costume idea). Page 2 waits until Script 1; pages 3 and 4 wait for the rounds. If you cut page 3 on its dashed line, hand out the Round 2 half when Round 2 starts.

Script 1 · Opening

READ ALOUD

Read this when everyone has a name tag and a booklet. Point to the Legend poster when you reach the legend.

READ ALOUD

Good evening, and welcome to Candlewick Hall! I am Detective Ira Gilchrist, and I came tonight, like all of you, for the Candlewick Costume Ball: candlelight, masks, music and the finest costumes in Candlewick Hollow. Our host, Vesper Ravensworth, owner of the Hall and judge of the Costume Parade, promised us "an announcement that will change Candlewick Hollow" at nine o'clock sharp.

You all know the Legend of the Lantern Ghost. Every Halloween since the candle works opened, a single lantern drifts past the nine tall windows of the Lantern Gallery, from the first to the last, and winks out. They say it is the first chandler of the Hall, still checking every wick. Tonight, at about twelve minutes to nine, several of you saw it.

At nine o'clock, Vesper did not appear. We found Vesper in the window chair of the Lantern Gallery, a pumpkin cup of cider on the sill, asleep. Vesper never woke up. The town doctor has been and gone, and says this was no accident. The road down the hill is closed for the night, so nobody leaves until we know the truth.

Please open your booklet and read page 2 quietly now. Do not turn to page 3 until I start Round 1. Innocent guests may dodge questions about their secrets until their booklet says to share; only one person here may lie outright. Nobody may change what an evidence card says. Let's find out what happened at the Candlewick Costume Ball.

AFTER READING

Give everyone about five minutes for page 2, then start Script 2.

Scripts 2 & 3 · Rounds 1 and 2

READ ALOUD

Script 2 · Round 1 · The Grand Entrance

Open the Round 1 envelope.

READ ALOUD

Round one: The Grand Entrance. Open your booklet to page 3 and read the top half, Round 1, only. I am placing evidence one to four on the evidence table. Read them, but leave them there for everyone. You have about twenty-five minutes: share what your booklet tells you, ask your two questions and try your task. Start with someone you haven't talked to yet.

HOST NOTES

Put E1–E4 on the table. Give a five-minute warning. Express version: 15 minutes, no tasks.

Script 3 · Round 2 · The Lantern Ghost

Open the Round 2 envelope.

READ ALOUD

Round two: The Lantern Ghost. While you were talking, the town doctor sent a note, the Gazette's terrace camera gave up its photos, and a few other things turned up around the Hall. Please read the lower half of page 3, Round 2. Do not turn to page 4. I am placing evidence five to eight on the table. Tonight, times matter: fill in the timeline on your Detective Notes. If someone dodged you in Round 1, ask them again.

HOST NOTES

Put E5–E8 on the table. After this round comes the Costume Parade (page 12).

The Parade & Script 4 · Round 3

READ ALOUD

The Costume Parade interlude

> READ ALOUD
> Before we go on, Vesper would never forgive us for skipping the Costume Parade. Line up, everyone! One at a time, walk to the end of the room, strike your best pose and tell us who you are, in character. Then we vote for Best Costume with our applause.

Play some music. Let each guest pose for a few seconds, then vote by applause and write the winner on the Best Costume award. Stay in character: this is a good moment for a little gossip.

🎃🎃🎃 Script 4 · Round 3 · Unmasked

Open the Round 3 envelope.

> READ ALOUD
> Round three: Unmasked. Something was hidden at Candlewick Hall tonight, and someone's story does not fit the clock. Please turn to page 4 of your booklet and read Round 3. I am placing evidence nine to twelve on the table. This is the last evidence of the night, so look at all twelve cards together. You have about twenty-five minutes.

The accusation

> READ ALOUD
> Detectives, it is time to accuse. Take a ballot and write who did it, how and why, plus up to three evidence numbers that prove it. No conferring. Fold your ballot and drop it in the bowl.

The Detective votes too. Allow about ten minutes.

The Legend & The Reveal

Using the Legend poster (file 35, page 1)

- Put it up by the door or a window before guests arrive, so early birds read it.
- Point to it when Script 1 reaches the legend. It contains no answers, so anyone may read it at any time.
- Guests will argue about whether the Lantern Ghost is real. Let them: the evidence settles it by the end of the night.
- Want a prop? Hang a small LED lantern on a string near a window and swing it gently during Script 1.

How to reveal

1. **Collect every ballot.** Keep the bowl to one side.
2. **Ask for a volunteer** to read the solution, or read it yourself if you prefer. Hand them file 99. Page 1 says STOP; that is fine now.
3. **The reader turns to Script 5** and reads it aloud. It reveals who did it, how the Lantern Ghost was made and the clues that prove it.
4. **Let the guilty guest take a bow.** Applause is required.
5. **Score the ballots** with the rules in file 99 (also printed on the ballot sheet).
6. **Hand out the awards** from file 34: Best Detective, Best Costume, Best Bluffer and Spookiest Alibi.

> **READ ALOUD (BEFORE THE REVEAL)**
>
> Every ballot is in. Our volunteer will now open the solution and read us the truth. Keep your theories to yourselves for one more minute.

> **TIES**
>
> If two detectives tie on points, the one with more correct evidence numbers wins. Still tied? The best costume of the two decides.

Hosting Tips

Keeping it moving

- Give a five-minute warning before each round ends.
- If someone is stuck, ask them to read their Share lines aloud to the room.
- Quiet guest? Ask them one of your own questions, or ask a chatty player to “interview” them for the Gazette.
- Running late? Shorten rounds, never skip one: every round holds evidence.

Big groups

- **15–20 guests:** pairs share optional booklets (page 5).
- **21–28 guests:** run two parties side by side, each with its own printed set and its own Detective. Play the rounds at the same time, then compare ballots and crown one Best Detective.
- **Younger guests under 12:** pair them with an adult as a team and let them be the evidence reader.

Keeping it cozy

- The game is for ages 12+ and clean: no gore, no drinking tasks, no flirting and no jump scares.
- Nobody has to act. Reading a line straight from the booklet is perfectly fine.
- Vesper is never described in a scary way: Vesper simply falls asleep in a chair and never wakes.

> **PLAYING AGAIN?**
> Each group can only solve the mystery once, but the kit is reusable for a different group: print fresh booklets, ballots and Detective Notes, or lend the files to a friend for their own costume party.

Drinks, Snacks & Table

ALL ALCOHOL-FREE

Every drink here is alcohol-free, so teens, families and drivers are all included. Nothing in the game asks anyone to drink.

Drinks

- **Hot apple cider:** warm apple juice with cinnamon sticks, cloves and orange slices. Keep it in a slow cooker, like the Hall's urn.
- **Pumpkin spice cocoa:** hot chocolate with a pinch of pumpkin pie spice and whipped cream.
- **Lantern punch:** orange juice, ginger ale and pineapple juice with orange slices floating on top.

Snacks

- **Pumpkin pie bites** or mini pumpkin muffins, in honor of the pies served at ten.
- **Caramel apple slices** with toothpicks.
- **Roasted pumpkin seeds** and a big bowl of popcorn.
- **Cheese and crackers** cut into moon shapes.

Table setting

- A dark tablecloth with mini pumpkins, autumn leaves and the paper bats from file 35.
- LED candles and battery tea lights (never real flames near costumes).
- The Candlewick Hall table sign at the entrance and the Evidence Table sign by the cards.
- A pumpkin-shaped mug for "Vesper's cup" as a centerpiece prop. Keep it empty.

> **ALLERGIES**
> Ask guests about allergies when you send invitations. Pumpkin seeds and nuts are common allergens; label the bowls.

Printing & Cutting

LETTER OR A4

- **Paper size:** use the US-Letter or A4 folder to match your paper. Print at "Actual size" or 100%.
- **Black and white is fine.** Text is near-black on light paper, and rounds are marked by 1, 2 or 3 pumpkins plus the words ROUND 1, 2 or 3.
- **Booklets (10–23): print single-sided.** Page 3 has Round 1 above a dashed line and Round 2 below it; cut it apart if you like and hand out Round 2 later. Single-sided printing stops later rounds showing through. File 24 holds all 14 booklets, each starting on an odd page.
- **Evidence cards (30):** pages 1–2 are the cards; page 3 is optional card backs. Print page 3 on the back of pages 1 and 2 (flip on long edge) so the helper can cut face down, or skip it to save ink.
- **Invitations (02), name tags (31), ballots (32):** cut on the dashed lines.
- **Detective Notes (33):** one copy per player.
- **Awards and table signs (34):** one award per page; fold the table signs on the dotted line.
- **Legend and decor (35):** poster, cut-out pumpkins and bats, banner pennants and photo props.
- **Solution (99):** print it last, face down, without looking. Or keep it on a phone.

CARD STOCK

Name tags, table signs, awards and banner pennants look best on light card stock (65–80 lb / 170–220 gsm). Everything else prints on ordinary paper.

BOOKLETS ON PHONES

Every booklet is its own PDF, so you can text it to a guest. Ask them to read only page 1 before the party.